

2017 A-level Paper 2 : Personal Information Online (dual-passage)
Suggested Answer Scheme (*Examiners' Comments in italics*)

From Passage 1

1. what does the author suggest about the opening statement by referring to it as a 'truism'?
 [1]

From the Text	Inference
... oft-repeated phrase...circulating (l.1-2)	It suggests that the statement is a cliché/commonplace/hackneyed/an <u>obviously</u> correct claim/is self-evidently true/says nothing original/taken to be true because it is so widely accepted Do not accept: True on its own/correct/a fact/frequently said

Examiners' comments: *Weaker candidates thought that a truism is simply a fact or a true statement.*

2. What contrasts does the author make in lines 3-4 about the role played by users of internet services? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
... willing participants in the biggest bargain ... (l.2-3)	The contrast is between those users who voluntarily/choose to/are not coerced/agree to involve themselves/take part/engage in online services to reap the benefits [1] and
... or unwitting accomplices in its biggest scams (l.2-3)	those who unknowingly/unconsciously help to contribute to/are partners in dishonest ways of making money/hoaxes/cheating cases. [1]

Examiners' comments: *Most answers identified the nature of 'willing participants'. Significantly fewer recognised what the author was implying through the use of the term 'unwitting accomplices.' A good number mistakenly thought such people are victims.*

3. Using paragraph 2, identify **two** examples of how online services 'are monetised'. **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
...monetised either by marketing portions of web space to advertisers (l. 7-8)	One way is by charging/making money/ gaining profit from promoters of goods and services for putting advertisements on their webpages. [1]

through peddling our precious data to any organisation with an interest in re-purposing our information (l. 7-8)	Another way is by selling/trading personal information to any party that sees value in/can gain from re-using the information. [1]
---	--

4. What is the author implying about the internet by describing its 'tentacles' and 'insidious spread and reach'? (l. 35). [2]

From the Text	Inference and Suggested Paraphrase
tentacles insidious	The author is implying that the internet, like 'tentacles' of an octopus, is able to reach far and wide/has extensive reach/is pervasive in so many aspects of our lives. [1] The word 'insidious' suggests that this reach/infiltration is dangerous/a threat/ a malice/harmful in a way that is not obvious/very subtle/sneaky/stealthy/surreptitious/not discernible until much later. [1]

Examiners' comments: The majority of responses grasped the point the author's use of the metaphor 'tentacles'. Fewer noted and glossed 'insidious'.

5. Using material from paragraphs 3-5 only (lines 10-33), summarise what the author has to say about the way hosts of internet services are able to exploit our personal data.

Write your summary in no more than 120 words, not counting the opening words which are printed below. **Use your own words as far as possible.** [8]

Hosts of internet services are able to exploit our personal data because ...

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
a. We use the internet search engines billions of times each day... no shortage of personal data (l.10)	We search/use/depend on the internet so often each day that this produces an abundance/no paucity of/a staggering/massive amount of personal information online
b. which can be traded (l.11)	which can be sold/ commodified/people can buy.
c. Our unquenchable thirst to share every aspect of our lives(l.11)	Social media users have an insatiable desire/cannot stop/ are addicted to making known all areas of their lives
d. translates to ample commercial opportunities (l.12) <i>ei - do not charge fees = free</i>	which provides the means/ the chances for companies to exploit/ take advantage of to make money
e. Many (social media sites) have flourished (l.14) ...this is a business model that works (l.15)	and the fact that they have become very rich/extremely profitable/enjoyed tremendous economic success attests to the extent our data is exploited
f. Although users may be aware that information is constantly collected (l.16)	Although users may be very well know that data gathering goes on continuously/endlessly/without stop

g. they are usually ignorant of how it will be employed and who has access to it (l.17-18)	they are unaware/oblivious/not informed about how data is used and by who
h. ... lack of transparency (l. 18)	The problem of a dearth/ paucity of clarity in the terms of service
i. ... worsened by terms of service not written for public consumption /run to tens of thousands of words (l.18-20)/...take too long to understand (l.20-21)	is aggravated/compounded by writing that is obscure/unintelligible to the ordinary person/has excessive wordiness/verbosity
j. ...most sites have such broad licensing terms (l.21)	and have such vague/general/ambiguous terms that cover all kinds of circumstances/offer legal loopholes favouring the companies.
k. ...paying lip service to our 'ownership' (l. 22)	The users' contents only nominally belong to them/firms are insincere/only pretend to uphold the users' claim that the contents belong to them
l. Your treasured holiday photo could end up being featured... you would ... receive no remuneration (l.24-25)	and owners of personal data are not financially rewarded/paid/ given monetary compensation when it is used commercially.
m. ...blogs, photos and videos can be modified (l.27)	Personal data can be edited/changed/amended/altered/adjusted,
n. published (l.27)	posted/made available/made known/conveyed,
o. distributed (l.27)	circulated/shared with others/spread to other sites/media platforms,
p. retained (l.27)	or kept/stored/archived,
q. ... without their consent (l.28)	without permission granted/ when no mutual agreement was made.
r. stores... monitoring our choices to sell us further products(l.32)	Retail outlets are tracking/analysing/scrutinising our spending patterns/the consumer decisions we make to make us spend more
s. We gladly sign up in return for a tiny discount or voucher (l.32-33)	when we willingly give away our personal information in exchange for small perks/minimal reward/the opportunity to pay a little less for our purchase.

19 possible points

(1-2pts = 1m, 3-4pts = 2m, 5-6pts = 3m, 7-8pts = 4m, 9-10pts = 5m, 11-12pts = 6m, 13-14pts = 7m, 15pts and more = 8m)

Examiners' Comments:

Many candidates found the identification of a sufficient amount of the relevant material very challenging, with a number of the points being missed: this was most noticeable when towards the end of the passage the author refers to material being 'modified, published, distributed or retained without their consent'.

Some answers devoted too many words to explaining just one point (particularly the one concerning the deliberate opaqueness of the terms and conditions attached to various social media sites) thereby using up a significant proportion of their 120 words too quickly.

The ability of very many candidates to re-cast the original text into their own succinct and fluent prose was strong. Furthermore, the word limit was respected by almost all, with hardly any substantial amount of vocabulary lifted directly from the original text.

From Passage 2

6. Explain the author's use of the word 'insights' in line 2. [1]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
	The word 'insights' tell us that the study of swarm intelligence enables us to gain various applications/new knowledge/understanding/perspectives/discoveries/findings about how complex management systems can be carried out.

7. In Paragraph 2, the author implies that ant colonies exhibit the behaviours of 'decentralised, self-organised systems'. Give **two** examples of how the author supports this. **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
...agents... interact randomly and their interactions contribute to the emergence of 'intelligent' communal behaviour (lines 6-7)	There is no fixed/standard/set plan/routine/behaviour is spontaneous/unpredictable/. [1]
There is no single decision-maker : Each ant adjusts its behaviours based on countless interactions with others in the community (line	No individual ant is in control/leading the colony/issuing commands/dictating orders. [1] Each individual makes the necessary modification /amendment/ correction/adaptation/ in its behaviour as it works together with others in innumerable occasions/frequently. [1] Any 2 for 2 marks

Examiners' comments: *Stronger responses found the required examples with which the author supports her claim that ant colonies are 'decentralised self-organising systems'. Much more often recognised was the idea that the colony as a whole decides on an action. Some answers suggested this meant that no one ant was capable of leading the colony, which is not the same thing.*

A number of answers quoted the author's references to ants defending the colony and finding themselves food sources, but these are simply examples of how the technique of solving problems communally is of great benefit.

Almost all answers identified the final piece of evidence, that ants amend their behaviour as a result of communication with the fellow ants.

8. In the experiment described in paragraph 3, what methods are used by the 'networked users' who participated in the experiment to 'outperform their individual members'? [3]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
... collaborate in real time to answer questions, make decisions, generate ideas, and even express opinions (l.14-15)	The first method is to work together/collectively in a variety of task synchronously/there and then/immediately/at the same time. [1]

...to **explore** the group's decisions against their own and reach **compromises** (l.18-19)

The next method is to evaluate/investigate/compare strategies/solutions [1]

Lastly, they come up with a middle ground/moderated stance/ adopt a give-and-take approach to reach an agreement/consensus which satisfies everyone. [1]

Examiners' comments: Candidates covered the three methods used in the experiment by 'networked users' to 'outperform individual members.' Most responses did use their own words and this was often well done. A good number had difficulty in glossing 'real time' but almost all identified how the group came up with and evaluated new ideas, to arrive at a middle ground that satisfied everyone.

9. Using lines 30-34, what **two** examples are given as possible benefits of sharing data. Use **your own words as far as possible**. [2]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
Messages posted by these stranded people to social media sites could warn others about the incident, providing real-time update that may change other people's journeys. (l.30-32)	Information about train breakdowns shared on social media sites could alert others, providing 'live' reports of the situation which may allow them to decide on an alternative route. [1]
Taxi and bus companies pick up on this spike in demand via global positioning systems and dispatch more vehicles to the area. (l. 32-34)	Taxi and bus companies can respond to a surge in demand for their services through online tracking and send out more vehicles to the places where commuters are. [1]

10. In what **two** ways is the final statement an effective conclusion to the author's argument? [2]

From the Text	Inference
So, if we are looking at for a role model in a world of chaos and uncertainty, we could certainly do no worse than copy the humble ant.	The final sentence provides a neat summary of the author's key argument about the value of studying swarm intelligence. [1] Structurally, the final sentence gives a sense of completeness by linking back to the opening sentence about the behaviour of ants in a colony which we can learn from. [1] It relates back/reinforces the earlier/previously mentioned examples of disruption, natural disasters and disease and how the ant can be a role model/teach us valuable lessons about working together. Stylistically, the author switches to the use of the personal pronoun 'we' in the final sentence to connect with the reader to make the concern a shared one. [1]

From both passages

11. One writer thinks the collection and use of our personal data from the internet does not primarily benefit us, while the other believes it could benefit us all.
How far do you agree with the opinions expressed in these two passages? Support with examples drawn from your own experience and that of your society.

REQUIREMENTS. Candidates should:

- Refer to the key ideas from/opinions of both writers that are related to their contrasting conclusions on the benefits of collecting and usage of personal data
- Make a stand as to whether the collection of data is /is not beneficial for themselves and people in their own society in general by evaluating the opinions of both writers
- Support their stand with reasoned arguments and provide examples based on their own experience and their observations of their own society

Key Ideas from Lee:

Online users are providing copious amounts of personal data on a daily basis when they use search engines and when they compulsively share every aspect of their lives online. This data can be exploited by profit-driven media sites which this lucrative business has made them very rich. While online users are aware of the collection of their data, they do not really know how the data is used or who can access this data. There is a lack of transparency about the terms and conditions on many media sites. The terms are difficult to understand or too broad. Companies can make use of our data without our permission, and while they profit from it, none of the financial reward is received by the owners of the personal information. Advertisers and retail outlets use loyalty cards that come with small perks to induce shoppers to give away personal data which are then exploit commercially for targeted advertising. The danger of the loss of our private data is made worse by the all-pervading reach of the Internet and also the unstoppable nature of information circulated online.

Key Ideas from Andrew

Constant broadcasting our personal data and receiving online information produce swarm intelligence that can be beneficial to us in coping with more mundane inconveniences to major emergency situations or crises. People can receive real-time updates that allow them to make unplanned necessary decisions and allow others to render help or respond to the situation appropriately. The more information is shared and collected, the more potent this swarm intelligence will be. Data sharing and collection can lead therefore serve the greater good of society by protecting us in times of emergency.

Some Pertinent Questions to Consider for EXPLANATION and EVALUATION:

- Do consumers of free internet services in your society really know what happens to their data?
- has there been any significant shift in the attitudes of online users with regard to privacy and protection when it comes to sharing of photos and other images of children or other non-consenting people with the growth of the internet, especially social media?

- How much data collection is acceptable, and is there a threshold where it comes too much?
- Are there laws or new policies in place to protect the right to privacy of the people in your society?
- Can collection of data really be used to protect us?
- Should the government be more transparent about how they might use our data to protect us?
- Can the collection of data be useful in other contexts besides managing emergencies and crises?

Examiners' Comments

Most candidates engaged well with the topic and many wrote about how Singaporeans are proficient in the use of modern technology, and – in the context of store loyalty cards – the appeal of bargains.

Stronger scripts began with an effective opening by **seeing merit in both passages**, rather than simply agreeing entirely with one writer and disagreeing with the other. Others began their responses well by making reference to the **high incidence of personal mobile phone ownership** in Singapore as well as the government's effort to make the country a 'smart nation'. **Such details help to establish an effective context** for the candidate's ensuing discussion of the issues raised by the writers.

Weaker responses tended to be **short or were incomplete**. They often **focussed on only one passage**, and therefore did not have the breadth of discussion. Many **were too centred on personal experiences** of the advantages and disadvantages of data sharing. Some **echoed too closely the example of the use of swarm intelligence when trains break down**, limiting their answers to simple narratives of how this had happened to them which showed the author's view to be correct. There was a **lack of evaluation of the merits or otherwise of the writer's idea and line of argument**. Another feature of weaker responses was that they were **lacking in a considered and succinct conclusion**.

Stronger responses were **reflective or analytical**: for instance, they questioned whether people caught in such incidents communicate about them altruistically, to help their fellows avoid inconvenience, or whether such assistance is incidental to the main purpose, which is simply to express personal frustration and a sense of grievance. Furthermore, some candidates suggested that such hold-ups enabled other transport providers to cash in and charge inflated prices. Stronger responses **offered incisive and detailed expositions of other actual examples** of swarm intelligence – during the recent incidence of haze, for example – or of its potential for future benefit via the SG Secure app. Others pointed out the potential for mischief-making through the dissemination of misinformation and 'fake news'.

Another aspect of the passages which featured regularly in stronger responses was the subject of gathering and retention of personal information and some of its attendant issues: **does it constitute a threat, an infringement of one's liberty or, as many felt, is it a price worth paying for national security?** This topic provoked some original and mature debate, well beyond the simple 'yes, I use the internet, yes, I shop online' approach. Fruitfully, many candidates **cited and assessed positively the effectiveness of cyber-awareness lessons** they had received earlier in their education.